BOOKS

THE VIEW FROM THE MIDDLE KINGDOM

By Andrew Small



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The most impressive concentration of China expertise in India has often been found in the upper echelons of the Ministry of External Affairs. A striking cluster of the figures who shaped Indian foreign policy in the last two decades benefited from deep experience in Beijing. They informed a sophisticated debate on China at the government's top levels that was often worlds removed from the wider public discourse. That gap is closing. Shyam Saran's new book is not only valuable in its own right but forms part of a notable collection of scholarship from MEA China hands published recently. While touching on the Sino-Indian relationship, the greater value is in demystifying China itself: distilling its history, politics and strategic culture with sharpness and clarity, and creating the conditions for a richer public discussion about India's most potent adversary.

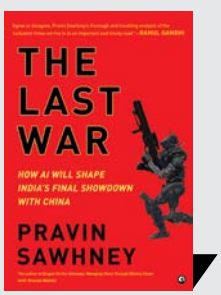
Chapter by chapter, Saran demonstrates why doing so matters. As he notes, "it is apparent that an imagined history is being put forward by China to seek legitimacy for its claim to Asian hegemony". Dismantling that imagined history is the implicit focus of the first half of his book. Saran takes on national myths that have been propagated by the Chinese Communist Party, then regurgitated by outside admirers and even many outside critics. These range from the tribute system to the influence of Confucian values on China's periphery, from the Silk Road to the legitimacy of Chinese claims over the territories of the Qing empire. On each topic, he forensically unpicks the narratives woven by Chinese officials and scholars, as well as some prominent western academics, that paint a picture of Beijing's future dominance in Asia not as a matter of raw power assertion but rather as the restoration of a natural and timeless order. As he argues, "[China's] contemporary rise is indeed remarkable but does not entitle it to claim a fictitious centrality bestowed upon it by history".

This is not just an exercise in myth-busting. Weaving his way from Chinese dynastic history to the latest developments since Russia's invasion of Ukraine, Saran paints an alternative picture that better fits the facts. It is an immensely rich primer, as useful for the seasoned expert as it is for newcomers to the subject. His even-handedness, and willingness to turn a self-critical mirror on Indian

Red Alert

New books on India's rising tensions with China

THE LAST WAR: How AI Will Shape India's Final Showdown with China
By Pravin Sawhney
ALEPH
₹999; 424 pages



An alarming—perhaps alarmist—take on the escalating rivalry in the Himalayas. Sawhney war-games a border war in which India is ignominiously outmatched by China in 72 hours. The takeaway: conflict is best avoided; India is better off seeking détente with both Pakistan and China—while enhancing its own military and technological capabilities.

